



## REVIEW ON JINGDEZHEN-MADE CHINAWARE DURING THE REIGNS OF KANGXI, YONGZHENG AND QIANLONG IN THE QING DYNASTY

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During Shunzhi Reign, the Imperial Porcelain Factory once tried to resume production and to make the *Gang* (also *Kang* or *Kong*, a type of large vessel storing water) decorated with dragon pattern and the breast board on imperial orders but failed. In the 10th year of Kangxi Reign, soon after sacrificial utensils were made here the ceramic industry in Jingdezhen was once again disrupted by the spread of war. Till the 19th year of Kangxi Reign, it renewed the production of imperial utensils and hereafter the ceramic industry experienced a rapid development in Jingdezhen.

Such rapid development resulted first of all from a series of measures taken gradually. In order to promote the production, Emperor Shunzhi issued the decree to abolish "the craftsman-register system," emancipating the craftsmen who had before been unable to separate themselves from the register and thus turning them into the employed labourers receiving pay in the Imperial Factory. Having been attributed into a specific financial account, the currency silvers were left every year for the Imperial Factory to pay for production, which offered the kilns a stable and abundant funds for expenses. In the 19th year of Kangxi Reign, the imperial government sent officials to manage the Imperial Factory, which helped the Imperial Factory establish a strong management. The so-called "manufacture in private kiln for official kiln," which had once burdened civilians heavily since the Ming Dynasty, now became a fixed system since the 19th year of Kangxi Reign, but a series of measures were taken to ensure fair trade and thus brought about the appearance of "officials and civilians vying in market." The intention of the Emperor to ask the Imperial Factory to model on the exquisite and superior products stored in the imperial palace which were produced by those famous kilns in the past dynasties virtually impelled Jingdezhen to learn from the famous kilns in other regions. The porcelain kiln industry started its prosperous development since the mid-term of Kangxi Reign.

Besides, some of the kiln-supervisors sent by the imperial courts also contributed somehow to the development of porcelain kiln industry in Jingdezhen, and the Imperial Factory were all named after the family names of the kiln-supervisors during the period.

**ZANG KILN (ZANGYAO)** From the 20th to the 27th years of Kangxi Reign, an official with the Ministry of Works named Zang Yingxuan was sent to the kiln to supervise the production. The variety of glaze of the porcelains made in the Zang kiln, in exquisite modelling and mainly with single colour, were of the snake-skin green glaze, the eel-skin yellow glaze, the auspicious green glaze (*Ji Cui You*), the spotted yellow glaze and so on.

**LANG KILN (LANGYAO)** From the 44th to the 51st year of Kangxi Reign, under the administration of Lang Tingji, Governor of Jiangxi, most of the products made in the Imperial Factory were the porcelain imitating the style of Xuande and Chenghua reigns, including the *Qinghua*, and white-glaze bodiless bowl, plate, and cup. The Lang kiln red among them was the most precious.

**NIAN KILN (NIANYAO)** In the 4th year of Yongzheng Reign, Nian Xiyao administered Banzhaguang of Huai'an Prefecture and concurrently took charge of business of Jingdezhen Imperial Factory. Thus, the Imperial Factory of Yongzheng Reign were usually called *Nian Yao* (Nian kiln), which produced a wealth of products, both modelling after antiques and blazing new trails, gaining remarkable achievements.

**TANG KILN (TANGYAO)** It was the name of the imperial ware made by the Imperial Factory when Tang Ying took concurrent charge of business of Jingdezhen Imperial Factory from the 2nd to 14th year and 17th to 21st year of Qianlong Reign. Actually, Tang Ying had taken up the post of resident co-ordinator as early as in the 6th year of Yongzheng Reign and was the real administer of business of "Nian kiln." He severed communication with the outside, concentrated his attention and energy, took great pains and efforts and spent three years working and living together with porcelain craftsmen. He learned quite a lot from his work and study about clay, glaze, body and fire-temperature control and directed the operation of kiln personally. He had devoted to the study of porcelain technology for more than 20 years. Tang kilns achieved so gigantic progress that a saying went that "there had been no such perfection as today (in times of Tang kiln) ever since the birth of porcelains."

The bodies of porcelains made in the three reigns of Kangxi, Yongzheng and Qianlong were delicate and pure, with glaring and smooth glaze, well-balanced and standard modelling, exquisite and beautiful pattern, which represented the topmost level of ancient porcelain craftsmanship in China. Tracing to its reason, it could be attributed to the improvement in all key links in the porcelain production chain: the finer methods, the more consummate skills, and the more advanced technology.

**CAREFULLY CHOOSING RAW MATERIALS FOR FINE PORCELAINS** The raw material of porcelains of Jingdezhen included porcelain stone, kaoline, glaze stone, glaze ash, etc., whose varieties were all in readiness and abound in reserve. By experiment, they identified the external characteristics of those fine-quality raw materials and further decided on the criteria for